constituent pressure, sidelining efforts may fail to change their behavior or result in cooperation. Additionally, this strategy depends heavily on the IO's ability to prevent leaks and press coverage of populist–IO interactions. Populist leaders are unlikely to engage secretly if they suspect that the information might eventually be exposed, thereby jeopardizing their domestic standing. Of course, such concerns are more dire when IOs are salient domestically and thus likely to provoke a strong reaction among the public.

The use of secrecy also raises significant normative concerns. Transparency is often considered a cornerstone of good governance (Besley and Burgess 2002), and increasing secrecy in IOs could invite accusations of hypocrisy and corruption. Many IOs advocate for greater transparency among their member states (Hollyer, Rosendorff, and Vreeland 2014), and adopting secretive practices themselves risks undermining the IOs' credibility and legitimacy.

Furthermore, secrecy can inadvertently reduce democratic accountability. When citizens are unaware of their government's interactions with IOs, they lose an essential channel for holding both domestic leaders and IOs accountable (Hirose et al. 2024; Clark, Dolan, and Zeitz 2025). While secrecy may keep populist states engaged with IOs, it also diminishes the ability of constituents to influence or understand global governance processes.

An additional risk is that secrecy can empower populists to continue their public attacks on IOs while privately benefiting from their operations. By obscuring the benefits that IOs provide, this approach allows populist leaders to perpetuate misleading narratives about the role and value of IOs, thereby deepening public distrust. Over time, this dynamic can erode public understanding of the importance of IOs and further entrench populist influence even as populist leaders accrue material benefits from IOs.

Sidelining populists' constituents is therefore a complex yet often effective strategy. IOs should weigh the benefits of retaining populist participation against the risks of reduced transparency, weakened public accountability, and potential backlash. To mitigate these risks, IOs could consider pairing this approach with targeted public outreach efforts, ensuring that the broader public understands the value of their work without their directly confronting populist leaders.